

years) is approximately Rs 150 crore, but has the potential to grow rapidly. This segment is currently driving growth in beauty products, colour cosmetics and fragrances. While the 6-10 years segment is getting a new look through re-bonding and hair colour, the teenagers are already dabbling with surgical procedures. From skin lightening to cosmetic surgeries, natural flaws are being lasered out at a very early age.

Be it to please the boyfriend or win the next beauty pageant, these kids are not willing to wait for time and tide. If hormones are playing truant, they deal with it by undergoing the laser treatment for hair and if their face is not perfectly shaped, they align it by using botox. If girls are not the perfect 34B by the time they are 15, they seek solace in implants. If the nose is not perfectly rounded, they get a rhinoplasty done. A case in point is 17-year-old Shivya Ahuja, who has been undergoing hair removal laser treatment from the time she was 15. She says: "The treatment has made a lot of difference to my appearance."

It's almost as if adults are trapped
HEP LOOK: Youngsters at A Cut Above Children salon in Chennai



SHRIYA PATIL

"If we have consent from parents of minors and the doctor is confident, it is ethical to operate on them."

DR VIJAY PANJABI
PRESIDENT, IMA, MAHARASHTRA

PRETTY CONFIDENT:
Akansha gets a facial at Franck Provost, Mumbai
inside bodies of children, and they will go to any extent to change their image. When children behave like adults and try to look older than their age, their emotional growth can be skewed. Points out Dr Rajendra Barve, counsellor and president of the Bombay Psychiatric Society, "Once such people reach the age of 40 or 45, they want to go back to the childhood they've missed and start behaving in an immature manner."

Teachers are also warning of the impact on educational progress and personality development that this trend may have. "There are some parents who want their children to lose their childhood before time. Parents are encouraging their children to groom themselves. Young parents are very conscious, with so much drama on television and beauty pageants. However, children today are very resilient and those interested in academics are focused although they have so many temptations," says Jessie Vaz, principal, Jamnabai Narsee School, a posh suburban school in Mumbai, where children of celebrities study.

Call it the curse of the information age or blame it on a society that's in the grips of a consumer tsunami, the first victim of this disturbing trend is childhood. Rather than discouraging this trend, parents are fuelling it further as they see grooming as a measure of social success. During their summer vacations, Arjun, 14, and his sister Goonj, 8, are regular customers at Cleopatra, a beauty salon and daytime spa in Chandigarh. They were initiated into salon service by their mother Kajal Arora, a housewife, who shells out Rs 4,500 a month for the service. "They are developing a look-good and feel-good outlook," she says, adding that the price is worth the "smart" tag her children will get.



H K RAJASHEKAR